"Mr Vikas, this is no small matter," the man said. "Your bank accounts have allegedly been used to launder Rs 380 crore linked to child trafficking and organ transplants in Thailand. We've identified the parents who deposited money into accounts linked to your Aadhaar in the hopes of saving their children."

The accusation was as extreme as it was outlandish. "This is not true," Vikas muttered. The officer immediately softened his tone. "Sir, this is clearly a misuse of your details. But there's a formal process we must follow to clear your name."

And so the trap was set. Over the next few hours, Vikas found himself pulled into an elaborate charade. The 'officer' explained that a high-powered panel, involving representatives from the apex court, RBI and CBI, was overseeing his case. "They recommend a refundable security deposit," the caller said. "This will demonstrate your willingness to cooperate. It's the fastest way to resolve this."

Vikas hesitated. "You'll receive stamped certificates for every payment," the man reassured him. The ruse deepened. The scammers asked about his savings, subtly prodding him to reveal all his financial assets. At first, Vikas resisted. But their courtesy, their insistence on "protecting his honour", eroded his defences. He ended up revealing details of all his funds. "You'll need to liquidate these," the caller said.

Vikas obeyed. Four times over the next 20 days, he visited his bank, took a loan against his FDs keeping his phone on in front of the manager and transferred the money. Each transfer was followed by a stamped certificate that seemed official, authentic.

Vikas didn't inform his family. The scammers warned his phone was under surveillance. "If you mention this case to anyone, they'll be implicated too," the caller warned. Vikas couldn't bear the thought of his daughter or son-in-law, both professionals in Bengaluru, being dragged into the nightmare.

By the 21st day, Vikas had transferred Rs 2.16 crore. His savings were nearly depleted. Yet the calls continued, demanding another Rs 22 lakh

By the 21st day, Vikas had transferred Rs 2.16 crore. Yet the calls continued, demanding another Rs 22 lakh. This time, he didn't have the money readily accessible. A friend dropped in. Noticing his unease, the friend pressed for answers. Vikas finally broke down, revealing the ordeal. Together, they went to the state DGP—a former colleague. The DGP was aghast. "How could you fall for this?" he asked.

But there was no time for recrimination. The police sprang into action, alerting banks and tracing transactions. By sheer luck, Rs 1.7 crore was found in a frozen account in Mumbai. Later, Vikas confessed that what shocked him the most was "how they controlled my mind. They created such fear, spoke with such respect, that I couldn't question them. I was a prisoner in my own home, in my own mind".

-Rohit Parihar

profile of an individual. The criminals first establish their authority by displaying knowledge about the victim's family, recent travel or financial assets, use it to extricate more confidential details, and then strike. The next step can even include threats. "The owner of a nursing home in Hyderabad was threatened that his two daughters staying in Mumbai would be kidnapped if he did not comply. While investigating a suspected mule account, we discovered that substantial sums had been transferred from the doctor's account. When approached, he was initially hesitant to share any information, fearing for his daughters' safety," says Samiran Baishya, Additional SP (Crime), Morigaon, Assam. Baishya has cracked hundreds of cybercrime cases originating from the district, especially Lahorighat, which is said to have become another Jamtara, the Jharkhand town that gained infamy as India's "phishing capital" in the first wave of cyber fraud.

Having pinned down the victim, the scammers make the raptor's last move—of extracting money. Typically, it is under the guise of a 'returnable security deposit to the government' for a resolution of the case in their favour. That amount could rise incrementally as the victim shows willingness to cooperate. For instance, a Jaipur-based former IGP (see case study *'They made me a prisoner in my home'*) ended up making security deposits worth Rs 2.16 crore over 21 days at the behest of the fake court before realising he was being scammed. Rabia forked out Rs 17 lakh in instalments as security deposit. In some cases, the victim is even instructed to take loans or liquidate assets. This is what befell a lawyer in Bengaluru, who was told she was implicated in a drug trafficking case and persuaded to transfer Rs 14 lakh to avoid arrest. Her tormentors' psychological hold was so strong that she complied with increasingly demeaning demands, including a "strip search" to prove her innocence. Then they threatened to leak her nude videos to extort an additional Rs 10 lakh.

"Scammers operate with chilling precision," says Lavina Sinha, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Cyber Crime, Ahmedabad. "They weaponise emotions—panic at the thought of criminal action, and of public humiliation. They raise the stakes gradually, creating a suffocating spiral of fear. And then, they pivot. Sympathy enters the equation. An 'out' is offered, but at a steep price. For the victims, the line between reality and deception blurs. The damage they inflict isn't just financial, it's emotional, psychological, profoundly human." Many a victim has said that the "digital arrest"